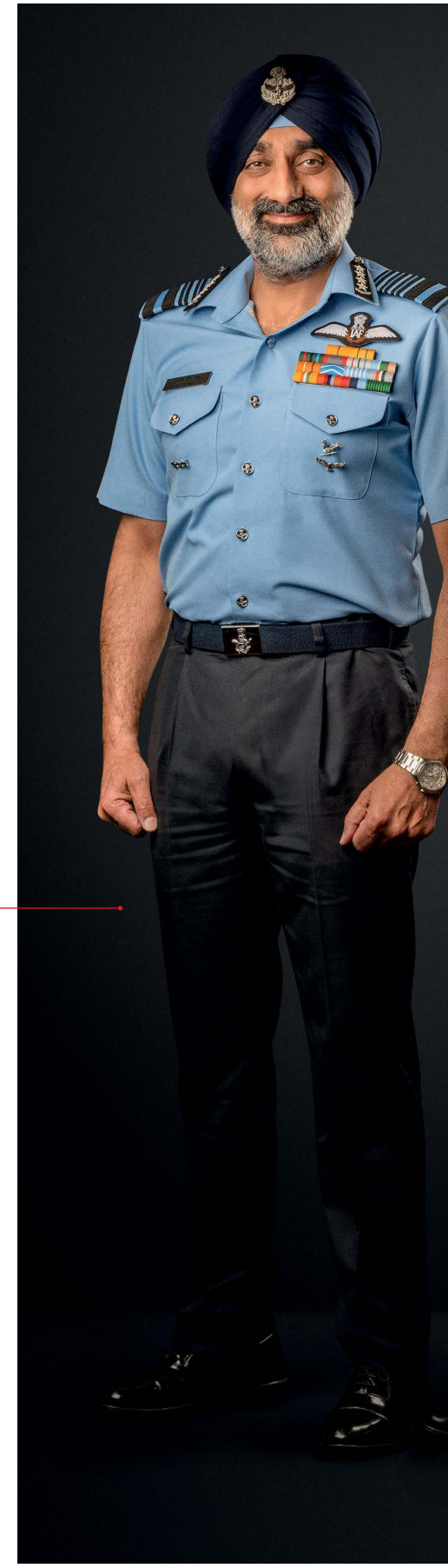
PUSHING THE ENVELOPE

With the world and the region in a state of constant turmoil, opinions about the preparedness of the armed forces often come from defence analysts. The audience at the India Today Conclave, however, got to hear all about it from the chiefs of the Indian army, air force and navy as they provided critical insights into India's evolving security landscape. Army chief Gen. Upendra Dwivedi underscored the deepening military and strategic collusion between China and Pakistan, warning that the threat of a two-front war is very real. The continued threat of cross-border terrorism remains a concern—and though local recruitment in Kashmir has declined, Pakistan remains an instigator, with 60 per cent of neutralised terrorists being nationals of that country.

Gen. Dwivedi reaffirmed India's vigilance along the Line of Actual Control with China, noting improvements in disengagement at friction points like Depsang and Demchok. Modern warfare, he said, has shifted to a continuous "grey zone" conflict, where India is in a constant state of "not war, not peace" and faces a "two-and-a-half-front" challenge. Gen. Dwivedi also called the Agniveer recruitment scheme a "great success".

Indian Air Force chief Air Marshal A.P. Singh pointed out the urgent need to modernise air combat capabilities. He dismissed speculation about India acquiring F-35 stealth fighters from the US, clarifying that no formal offer had been made. On China testing sixth-generation aircraft and the US granting funds to Pakistan for the maintenance of its F-16 fleet, he asserted the need to catch up with the latest technology. "Presently, we are the ones chasing new technology. We need to reach a stage where we call the shots and get such technology made in India. We need to be in a situation where the world will chase us," he said.



AIR CHIEF MARSHAL A.P. SINGH

Chief of the Air Staff

"We need to analyse (the US's F35), what the requirements are and what comes along with it. The cost is a part. We have not given it a thought. No offer has been made till now"

GEN. UPENDRA DWIVEDI

Chief of the Army Staff

"India is in a state of 'not war, not peace', and is saddled with all five generations of war—trench, indirect, manoeuvre, hybrid and AI warfare"